

his role to take sail through a bigger challenge—to help build an electronics product nation.

Aboard a new challenge

In 2008, the Prime Minister formed a task force which set the agenda for the ESDM (electronics system design and manufacturing) industry to formulate the National Electronics Policy and the Semiconductor Policy. The task force, which was the first to coin the term ESDM, included names such as Dr Ajay Chowdhry, Dr Ajay Kumar (then Joint Secretary, later Defence Secretary), and Sanjay Nayak, among others. “We coined the term ESDM to emphasise the integration of hardware, software, systems, design, and manufacturing,” he recalls. The group projected that by 2020, imports of electronics would surpass those of oil, which indeed came true, galvanising the government and industry to focus on domestic electronics production, design, and manufacturing.

In 2024, Sanjay joined a task force with Dr Ajai Chaudhary, Dr Satya Gupta and others to create a blueprint for making India an electronics product nation. This task force has proposed an investment of ₹44,000 crores (approximately \$5 billion) for this effort, and many specific recommendations, based on a practitioner’s perspective on the challenges and opportunities for India to develop world-class product companies.

Even with all his achievements, never once does Sanjay take credit, all throughout narrating his story in third person. “Solving any big problem is not something one can do alone. I’ve been privileged that at every point in my career, I was surrounded by mentors from whom I learned a lot. I was also surrounded by my colleagues and co-founders, who are outstanding people, and we always complemented each other in whatever we did,” he shares.

Sanjay’s life has been dominated by the principles he imbibed on the sports field. “A great sports person never gives up after a bad day. They always come back with the hope of doing better. This optimism has been a strength in my career,” he states.

Like the protagonist of his favourite movie *Anand*, Sanjay’s optimism is not exclusive to realism. Instead, it is a fire that burns bright, keeping him and his team warm during the storm. Sanjay believes “Optimism is essential for an entrepreneur. It keeps you motivated and happy.”

Sanjay’s co-founders and mentors continue to be amazed by his optimism, noting that they have yet to encounter anyone more hopeful. For Sanjay Nayak, there is always a path forward, and his journey stands as a testament to resilience, determination, and the enduring power of optimism. **EFY**



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